

Shaozhe Cheng

Curriculum Vitae

July, 2026

Department of Psychology & Neuroscience Homepage: <https://chengshaozhe.github.io>
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Positions

Postdoc Associate, Duke University & UCLA 2024-
Collaborators: [Tamar Kushnir](#), [Michael Tomasello](#), & [Tao Gao](#)

Education

Ph.D., Cognitive Psychology, Zhejiang University 2023
Advisors: Jifan Zhou (ZJU), Mowei Shen (ZJU), Tao Gao (UCLA)
Dissertation: *On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires* (**Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award**)

B.S., Psychology, Shanghai Normal University 2016

Research Interests

Computational cognitive science; social cognition; decision-making; agency; human–AI coordination; cooperative AI

Awards and Honors

- Travel Award, Charles Lafitte Foundation 2026
- Early-Career Scholar, [Intentions & AI Workshop](#) 2025
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang Province 2024
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang University 2023
- Grant for Excellence in Doctoral Research 2022
- Cognitive Science Society Conference Award 2021
- National Scholarship for Postgraduates 2017

Publications

Cheng, S., & Tomasello, M. (invited submission). Can We Get to Human-Like Intelligence Via Language Alone?

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026). The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. (Presented as a **spotlight** research talk (top 10%) at [Conference on Society-Centered AI](#).)

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Should we commit or should we switch? Goal alignment in sequential social coordination. *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. (Presented as an oral talk (9.3%))

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Spontaneous coordination with self-commitment: How the presence of others alters the strength, goal and timing of commitment. *Cognition*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2025.106287>

Zhai, S[#], **Cheng, S[#]**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2024). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. *Child Development*, 95(1), 7-15.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/cdev.13955>

[#] Shared first authors

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Tang, N., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2023). Intention beyond desire: Spontaneous intentional commitment regulates conflicting desires. *Cognition*, 238, 105513. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2023.105513>

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment through an internalized theory of mind: Acting in the eyes of an imagined observer. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment as goal perseverance in human planning [Workshop on Social Intelligence in Humans and Robots]. *The annual meeting of the Robotics: Science and Systems 2022 (RSS 2022)*. (presented as a **spotlight** paper at <https://social-intelligence-human-ai.github.io/>)

Cheng, S., Shi, B., Zhao, Y., Tang, N., Xu., H., Gao, T., Zhou J., & Shen, M. (2017) Rethinking attention: A reinforcement learning model of attention. *Chinese Journal of Applied Psychology*.

Conference Presentations

[^]Students I supervised

Cheng, S., Gao, T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026, June 18–20). *The agency gap: Testing human–human and human–AI collaboration using a minimal coordination game* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Philosophy and Psychology 52nd Annual Meeting, Baltimore, MD, United States.

Kushnir, T., & **Cheng, S.** (2026, Apr). Children’s strategic joint decision-making with minimally social artificial agents. Pre-Conference Workshops on *Strategic decision-making in childhood*, *Cognitive Development Society (CDS)*, Montreal, Quebec, Canada.

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026, Feb). The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. Presented as a spotlight research talk (top 10%) at *Conference on Society-Centered AI*, Duke University, Durham, NC, USA.

Cheng, S., Main, K[^], Kushnir, T., & Gao, T. (2025, May). Spontaneous social coordination through visually grounded theory-of-mind in children’s and adults’ decision-making. Poster accepted at *the Annual Meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, St. Pete Beach, Florida, USA.

- Cheng, S., Main, K[^]., Gao, T., & Kushnir, T. (2025, May).** Children's Spontaneous Commitment and Intention Coordination in Individual and Social Decision-Making Contexts. Talk at the Symposium: Unravelling early and middle childhood decision-making: From individual characteristics to social influences, *Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting (SRCD 2025)*, Minneapolis, MN, USA.
- Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024).** Intentional commitment as a spontaneous presentation of self. Poster presented at *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.
- Cheng, S., Zhu, J[^]., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024).** From attention capture to social coordination: “Abrupt onset” rallies joint planning. Poster presented at the 2024 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.
- Zhu, J[^]., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Viewing others as committed agents. Poster presented at *the 2023 SPSP Annual Convention. Society for Personality and Social Psychology*.
- Zhu, J[^]., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Intention as hierarchical constraints in human planning. Poster presented at *the 2023 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society*.
- Zhu, J[^]., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shui, R., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). People expect others to plan with consistency to intention. Poster presented at *the 2023 APS Annual Convention. Association for Psychological Science*.
- Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. Oral presentation at *the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.
- Cheng, S.**, Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the 47th annual meeting of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology, 6/28/21 – 7/2/21, Virtual-SPP*.
- Cheng, S.**, Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2020). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the annual meeting of the Vision Sciences Society, 6/19/20 – 6/24/20, Virtual-VSS*.
- Cheng, S.**, Xu, H., Tang, N., Zhou J., Chen, H., Liang, J., Gao T., & Shen, M. (2018). Hierarchical Constrains on the Distribution of Attention in Dynamic Displays. Poster presented at *the 30th APS Annual Convention*.

Invited Talks

- Cheng, S. Test commitment in humans (adults and kids) and AIs (RL agents and LLMs) in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the [Intentions & AI Workshop](#), CA, 6/2/2025.

Cheng, S. On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires. Talk given at the Tomasello Lab, Duke University, NC, 4/18/2025.

Cheng, S. Spontaneous coordination through intentional commitment: How adults and children resolve conflicting desires in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the Communication Colloquium, UCLA, CA, 4/10/2025.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant **Zhejiang University: Psychology and Artificial Intelligence**
(undergraduate course), 2018 & 2019

Guest Lecturer **Zhejiang University: Evolutionary Psychology** (undergraduate seminar), 2017 & 2018
Zhejiang University: Advanced Psychological Research Methods
(graduate course), 2019 & 2020

Mentorship

<i>PhD Students</i>	Jingyin Zhu (ZJU '24)
<i>Master Students</i>	Shaoyan Hao (ZJU '25)
<i>Undergraduate Senior Theses</i>	Kaelin Main (Duke '25) Camila Acquarone (Duke '27)

Award & Funding to Trainees

Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Riley MacDermott (Duke '27)	2026
Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Kaelin Main (Duke '25)	2024

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Science Robotics
Journal of Experimental Psychology: General Cognition
The Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society
Society for Philosophy and Psychology